

Bala's family came from a long line of handloom weavers. They had perfected the art of drawing, dying, warping and weaving the yarn. But it was a hard work. Unless Bala, his mother, father, sisters and cousins helped with the work, Appa could never weave the lengths, he needed.

Bala would often see Appa and Amma weave bundles of cotton into beautiful sarees with checks or patterns. He hoped to weave someday. He would also help Amma and sisters, roll, press and pack the sarees.

Bala wondered, "Amma, why you never wear the beautiful sarees we make?"

Amma said, "I can do that only if we become a very rich family."

Bala woke up suddenly as he felt someone tap his head.

"Are you ready to go?", asked Appa.

"Yes Appa.", said Bala and started counting the bags around him.

Bala was going with Appa to Chennai to help him carry the sarees. Appa said, "We will get a better price for the sarees, if we sell directly to ladies in Chennai than to traders in Pollachi or Coimbatore."

They walked to the bus stop and had to wait for nearly one hour for the bus. It took them to Coimbatore junction, and from there they left in a train to Chennai. The train journey was not very comfortable. "Don't worry Bala. Our return will be more comfortable as we will be able to reserve tickets," said Appa. They reached Chennai and went to Purasaiwalkam, where Appa's friend lived.



The next morning Appa was ready with places to go to sell the sarees. As Bala was new to city traffic, he held father tightly.

Soon, they reached a big house after what seemed like many hours. The guard at the door let them in. They sat in a big hall and unpacked the sarees.

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